



— FREE RESOURCE · GUIDE 2 OF 5

Essay 1 – Leadership Experience

How to choose, structure and write the leadership essay using the STARL method, with two full worked examples.

ABOUT THE EXAMPLES.

All names, institutions, universities, statistics and organisations below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful essays, changed to show technique. Yours must be real.

THE LIVE QUESTION.

Describe a time when you demonstrated leadership. In your answer, please address the following:

- What was the context or challenge you faced?
- What specific actions did you take as a leader?
- What was the outcome, and what did you learn?

WORD LIMIT:

Minimum 100 / Maximum 300 words.

WHAT IS BEING SCORED.

Whether things changed because of you. Chevening looks for examples with clear results: driving change in a community or organisation, improving outcomes for others, solving a specific challenge, implementing something with tangible impact.

STRUCTURE.

STARL: Situation, Task, Action, Result, Learning.

WORD PLAN AT 300 WORDS

BEAT	WORDS
Situation (context / challenge)	40
Task	30
Action (specific actions as a leader)	110
Result (outcome)	70
Learning	50

Part one: choosing the episode

Selection matters more than writing. A well-chosen story writes itself.

Four filters

1. Can I name an exact number that moved? (Not the size of the problem — the size of the change.)
2. Did I decide things, or execute someone else's decisions?
3. Is it from work or voluntary activity? (Avoid school and university examples.)
4. Did I have to bring people with me who did not have to follow me? (Influence without authority outscores authority.)

Leadership does not require a leadership title

You do not need to have been a chief executive, director, manager or elected official. Leadership shows wherever you took responsibility, exercised judgement, moved people and produced a result.

Chevening is looking for a force multiplier: somebody who identified a problem nobody had claimed, mobilised whatever was available, and delivered something measurable.

Choose evidence, not titles

Weak: "I became president of X, team leader of Y and project manager of Z."

Strong: "When X emerged, I recognised that Y was blocking progress. I took responsibility for fixing it by doing Z, which meant persuading A and mentoring B. As a result, C changed."

The job title test.

Remove your job title from the finished essay. Do your actions still demonstrate leadership? If not, rebuild around what you decided rather than what you were called.

Strong and weak candidates

STRONG	WEAK
You spotted a problem nobody had claimed	You delivered a project you were assigned
You persuaded people outside your reporting line	Everyone involved reported to you
Something failed partway and you changed course	Everything went to plan
You can name what continued after you left	The work ended with the funding
The outcome was measured by somebody else	You are the only source for the result

A well-evidenced pilot in forty villages beats a vaguely described national programme. Assessors look for causation they can trace to you.

If your best example is imperfect

Use it, and say what did not work. An honest account of something that half-succeeded beats a polished account of something unverifiable. Do not inflate a marginal role.

Part two: the three failures that cost the most marks

1. Treating a position as proof.
 2. Defining leadership instead of demonstrating it.
 3. Stopping at Action and giving a vague “success” with no numbers or learning.
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Part three: naming in this essay

Name the institution you worked through, the official you moved (with title), the thing you founded, and the artefact that changed (form, guideline, dataset, procedure), by its actual name.

Rule: the name and what you did with it go in the same sentence.

Do not name beneficiaries, patients, clients or minors.

Aim for four to eight proper nouns in 300 words.

Part four: writing it, beat by beat

S. Situation / Context / Challenge (~40 words)

Open on the problem, sized with an exact number.

Good openings

- Contradiction: two facts that should not coexist.
- Failed assumption.
- Unowned gap.
- Lived experience converted immediately into a statistic (if true of you).

Avoid

“Leadership has always been my passion.”

“Since childhood I have wanted to serve my community.”

T. Task (~30 words)

What became your job, under what constraint, with what at stake. Without this, later achievements are ambiguously credited.

A. Action – specific actions as a leader (~110 words)

Every sentence should contain a decision.

Use the obstacle chain.

Name influence (whom you persuaded, what changed their minds).

Include prioritisation under constraint.

Include one adaptation beat (something that failed and the redesign it forced).

Stay in “I” while keeping the team visible and attributing precisely.

R. Result / Outcome (~70 words)

Exact numbers first, then reach. Use the impact ladder (direct metric → institutional adoption → durable artefact).

Name the artefact.

One micro-case sentence after the numbers is powerful.

Never invent a number.

L. Learning (~50 words)

Two or three sentences. A working principle drawn from the specific thing that went wrong earlier in the essay. This answers the live “what did you learn?” requirement cleanly.

Part five: two full sample answers

All names, places and statistics are anonymised and reinvented. Do not copy.

Sample one — civil registration (298 words)

I grew up in Sisan District, where fewer than half of children hold a birth certificate and therefore cannot sit national exams. Nationally coverage is 38 per cent; in Katiba Province it is 30. The barrier is not demand. The nearest registrar is 26 km away and opens three days a week.

After my three-province study for the Institute for Public Administration, I decided to test whether registration could be brought to families rather than the reverse, with no budget and no mandate.

I founded Kalima Registration Outreach and negotiated with the Katiba Midwives' Association to have their members issue notification slips at delivery, removing the document families most often lacked. Our first attempt used a printed guide; uptake stalled because it assumed literacy the mothers did not have. I rebuilt it as a spoken checklist delivered at the six-week clinic, trained 34 midwives, and, because we could reach only a fifth of the province, targeted the twenty wards with the lowest baseline coverage rather than the accessible ones. I then briefed Dr Amina Sesay, the Registrar General, on the results.

We registered 3,142 children across 40 villages and cut median distance to a registrar from 26 km to 4 km. Dr Sesay's office appointed me to the Civil Registration Technical Advisory Group, and the late-registration procedure I drafted was issued as national guidance in 2025. One boy, refused twice because his mother's own certificate had lapsed, sat his exams last November.

I learned that the families closest to a broken process know precisely why it breaks, and that my first design failed because I built for my own convenience rather than theirs. I now test every change with whoever carries its cost before it reaches a ministry.

Sample two — financial services (297 words)

Sahel Trade Finance declined four of every five loan applications from women running market businesses, while our default rate on those we approved was 2.1 percentage points below the portfolio average. We were not managing risk. We were mismeasuring it.

As a credit analyst with no authority over lending policy, I asked the finance director for three months and access to the archive to establish what our scoring model was actually rejecting.

I re-scored 1,214 declined applications against subsequent repayment behaviour, traced through the Molo Market Traders' Association ledgers. The model was weighting registered collateral, which women in our market rarely hold in their own name. I rebuilt the score around twelve months of cash-flow data and proposed a pilot. The credit committee refused, so I ran it as a bounded exception on 200 loans with a lower ceiling, which they accepted because the downside was contained. When the cohort outperformed, I brought the arrears data to the committee rather than the argument, and I asked the Association's chair, Mrs Fatou Njie, to speak to the committee directly.

Approvals for women-owned businesses rose 34 per cent across 8,140 active loans with no measurable increase in default. The cash-flow score is now our default model for unsecured lending below 500,000, and I was invited to present the method to the Bankers' Association working group on responsible lending, whose 2025 code adopted it as recommended practice.

I learned that a committee which will not accept an argument will often accept a small, bounded experiment, and that the experiment then does the arguing for you. I now design every proposal with a version small enough to be approved by people who disagree with me.

Part six: dos and don'ts

Do

- Choose one episode and go deep
- Open on the problem, sized with an exact number
- State what became your task, the constraint, and the stakes
- Name institutions, officials and artefacts with what you did attached
- Show at least three decisions that were yours
- Name whom you influenced and what changed their minds
- Include one failure and the redesign it forced
- Put two exact figures at the result
- Close on a principle drawn from what went wrong

Don't

- Define leadership or open with a proverb
- Use a school or university example
- List job responsibilities

- Name people or institutions with nothing attached
 - Name beneficiaries, patients, clients or minors
 - Write “we” where you mean “I”
 - Use the passive voice for your own work
 - Invent numbers
 - End on a feeling
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Part seven: checklist

While drafting

- ☐ One episode from work or voluntary activity
- ☐ Opens on the problem with an exact number
- ☐ Task, constraint and stakes stated
- ☐ At least three decisions that were mine
- ☐ Whom I influenced and what changed their minds
- ☐ One obstacle and the adaptation it forced
- ☐ Two exact figures at the result
- ☐ The artefact that changed, by its name
- ☐ Learning drawn from what went wrong

Before submitting

- ☐ All three live sub-questions visibly answered
- ☐ Four to eight proper nouns, each attached to an action
- ☐ No beneficiaries or minors named
- ☐ First person, team work attributed precisely
- ☐ Essay still shows leadership if job title is removed
- ☐ Every figure real and every name spelled correctly
- ☐ Dates and title match work history
- ☐ Gap exposed here is the gap Essay 3 closes

☐ Within 100–300 words

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